

ANDEAN ALTIPLANO

Silver salt flats hidden in the mountains

The Andean altiplano—literally, high plain—is the second largest mountainous plateau in the world after the Tibetan plateau in Asia. It is a landscape of extremes, surrounded by the mountains and volcanos of the central Andes. It has the world's highest navigable lake, Lake Titicaca, and the world's largest salt flat, the Salar de Uyuni. At an average altitude of 12,400 ft (3,750 m) above sea level, the air is thin, the sun is strong, winds can be fierce, and temperatures can fluctuate, making the altiplano a harsh place to live.

Harsh but fair

Despite the unforgiving conditions, the altiplano is also a land of strange beauty. The flat white expanse of the salt flats is, in places, adorned with three-foot-wide polygonal shapes created by the salt crystals, and incredible rock formations are sculpted by wind-blown sand. The mineral-rich lakes support flocks of flamingos

numbering in the thousands, and the plains and slopes are home to herds of vicuñas, which are bred by Andean peoples for their wool, and llamas, bred for their wool, skin, and meat.

The Andean altiplano's vegetation, known as puna grassland, is dominated by grasses and shrubs, many of which form tussocks or cushions. Low-growing, mat-forming yareta plants and tall, branching cacti grow in the stony soils. The puna ecoregion is divided into wet, dry, and desert areas depending on the amount of rainfall they receive annually. One region in the center of the Andes receives a meager 16 in (400 mm) of rainfall a year and experiences an eight-month long dry season.



STARTLING SPECIALIST
This frog has evolved to survive in the most oxygen-impooverished lakes on Earth. Large folds of extra skin give it an extra-large body surface area. This allows it to maximize absorption of oxygen from the water and the atmosphere.

TITICACA WATER FROG

HARDY CROPS

Quinoa is well-adapted to the dry sandy soils of the altiplano and has been grown as a food crop by Andean peoples for thousands of years. The altiplano is one of few places where agriculture is practiced 11,500 ft (3,500 m) above sea level.

QUINOA

Lake Titicaca is the highest navigable lake

ANDEAN FLAMINGOS

Uyuni is the largest salt flat on Earth

THREE FLAMINGOS

Three of the world's six flamingo species live in the altiplano. James and Andean flamingos are found in the region year-round, staying warm near hot springs during winter. In the summer, they are joined by flocks of Chilean flamingos.